

it *might* not be a good idea to use a PowerPoint template and then customise it too much. One colour or one font is fine, but no going beyond that. A lot of thought was put into the creation of those templates, so you're best off leaving well enough alone.

Use ClipArt and animation sparingly. Also do not overdo transition effects.

A good rule for pie charts is to limit the number of sectors to five or six. Honestly, if there were nine, would *you* be able to make sense of it in the time for which the slide was displayed? In addition, for charts in general, write out the information where it's most easily read—usually right in the pie or on the bar.

Tip

An oft-committed error is to prepare a chart without sufficient thought to what kind it should be, and equally oft-committed are such errors as what should be on the X and Y axes (in the case of bar graphs). Think hard about how best to *convey information*.

If you must have a complex chart, then, in the interest of readability, break it up into two slides. For example, with a pie chart, if you must have twelve divisions, keep seven on the first slide, with the seventh called “others.” Go into those others in the next slide.

Images...

...can lighten up the mood, just like some fonts can. But then again, don't use too many. Make sure they're relevant to the content, that they, while breaking the monotony, are also utilitarian. Avoid “cute” images; you'd be insulting the intelligence of some of those in the audience. Also avoid images that distract, such as any image with a lot of red in it when the slide has a blue background.

“Heavying” up the mood

In most cases, you need to be regular, straight, formal, conventional, and the like, with the occasional lightening up of the mood by the use of funky fonts and/or sound and video. But don't always be shy. If you *must* drive home a point, do so. Use unconventional,